

To: Board of Education
From: Dr. Jon Franco, Senior Chief of Operations
Brandon Coonrod, Senior Director of Transportation
Cc: Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent
Deborah Kafoury, Chief of Staff
RE: ACCESS Transportation
Date: June 9, 2026

The purpose of this memorandum is to provide additional context ahead of Tuesday's upcoming budget discussion and to formally address recent inquiries regarding ACCESS transportation. Specifically, this document reviews the requested information regarding the proposed transition to a centralized transportation hub model.

At the core of the ACCESS Hub option is an imperative to balance equitable student access, long-term operational sustainability, and rigorous fiscal responsibility, while continuing to robustly support students across the entire city. The current specialized transportation model has become increasingly difficult to sustain due to systemic route inefficiencies, excessively long ride times for students, significantly underutilized buses, and escalating baseline transportation costs. The proposed model seeks to correct these operational vulnerabilities while modernizing our delivery framework.

Student-Centered Priorities

The proposal outlined focuses on several critical, student-centered priorities designed to preserve service quality and support vulnerable families:

- **Maintaining Reasonable Access:** Ensuring that transportation remains a viable and accessible option for ACCESS students distributed across the municipality.
- **Reducing Ride Times:** Restructuring paths to minimize the administrative and physical burden of long commutes on developing students.
- **Balancing Ridership Loads:** Optimizing vehicle capacity configurations to systematically avoid overloaded buses and maximize resource deployment.
- **Prioritizing High-Need Communities:** Intentionally anchoring centralized hub locations within or adjacent to Comprehensive Support and Improvement (CSI), Targeted Support and Improvement (TSI), and Title I communities to preserve equity.



- **Mitigating Systemic Spillover:** Designing the transition to strictly limit or eliminate negative operational impacts on other regional school schedules and localized neighborhood routes.
- **Providing Comprehensive Transition Supports:** Deploying proactive infrastructure mitigation, including formal Safe Routes to School logistical assistance and coordinated district carpool matching frameworks.

Operational & Fiscal Analysis

A data-driven comparison between the current operating baseline and the proposed regional hub model demonstrates substantial optimizations in both systemic efficiency and fiscal discipline. Under the proposed hub model, buses would pivot to operating with multiple strategic runs instead of relying on long, single-destination dedicated routes.

Operational Metric	**Current Model Baseline**	**Proposed Hub Model Option**	**Net System Impact**
Dedicated Bus Routes	10 Routes	5 Routes	-50% Route Reduction
Total Bus Stops	125 Stops	13 Centralized Hubs	-112 Stops Localized
Average Route Time	71 Minutes	33 Minutes	-38 Minutes Saved (Avg) in
Estimated Annual Cost	$1,500,000	$1,000,000	**$500,000 delta that we will need to find tradeoffs for.**



*Financial Note: Total projected structural savings under this streamlined configuration are conservatively modeled at approximately **$1.0 Million annually**, providing critical relief to the general fund during this fiscal cycle.*

Regional Hub Architecture & Route Expectations

The proposed model creates a centralized grid across five primary geographic sectors (North, Northeast, Southeast, Southwest, and Northwest Portland). By establishing 13 centralized hub locations across these zones, the district can consolidate staging while sharply reducing individual student commute windows. Detailed scheduling parameters within the attached slides outline regional route times ranging from a minimum of approximately 22 minutes to a maximum of 39 minutes, representing a profound improvement over the current 71-minute average baseline.

The ACCESS Hub option represents a proactive adjustment to our transportation infrastructure. It generates $1M in recurring annual savings while directly improving the student experience via a 53% reduction in average trip lengths.

Meeting with ACCESS Families

On June 2, 2026, Senior Chief of Operations, Dr. Jon Franco, Senior Director of Transportation, Brandon Coonrod, Senior Chief of Academics, Kristina Howard, Senior Director of Schools, Michael Baird, and Chief of Schools, Dr. Isaac Cardona had a meeting with ACCESS families at ACCESS Academy.

The purpose of the meeting was to ground in the current state around ACCESS transportation and then to present the proposed HUB model. Approximately 30 people attended both in person and on-line. Parents expressed appreciation for looking at an alternative model and offered input regarding the proposed model. Some input received included:

- **Allow stops at locations other than middle schools.** Most elementary schools have some part of their footprint where a bus could stop without substantially disrupting an ongoing school day. Additionally, the same logic that suggests middle school stops in the morning suggests elementary school stops in the afternoon. Finally, some families would like the opportunity to join after-school programs at elementary schools nearer to them than ACCESS. We know that middle schools will be the core of the system, but some flexibility in specific cases would improve routes.

- **Add one bus on the eastside.** We asked for seven buses, and you've proposed five.

Six seems like a reasonable compromise that would keep PPS from needing very large buses. We'd request that this bus fill in the NE "donut hole" on the route map. This is our only recommendation that appears to come with more than a minimal cost, and it's important to us. Add stops at schools like Cleary, Laurelhurst, or Sunnyside, and include Hosford.

- **Improve equity by adding Title I stops in St. John's and Arbor Lodge.** George MS or Roosevelt HS, and Ockley Green MS or Chief Joseph ES. This is a key benefit of adding a route.

- **Move Tubman MS stop to Sabin or Irvington.** Tubman is in an inconvenient location, hemmed in by I-5 and Emanuel hospital. Almost all families who indicated that they would use Tubman preferred stops at Sabin (in particular) or Irvington. Sabin and Woodstock are middle-income neighborhoods with high concentrations of ACCESS families that are not served especially well by the proposed system. We are aware that the 40-minute threshold may become an issue here and are willing to problem-solve with you.

- **Move Lane MS stop to Woodstock ES.** Every family that indicated it would use Lane as a stop would be served as well or better with Kellogg and Woodstock as stops. Woodstock has new Safe Route improvements. This change slightly shortens the time spent on the route.

- **Consider replacing Robert Gray MS or adding another mid-SW stop.** This might best be accomplished by convening SW parents and achieving consensus. Ida B. Wells/Rieke, Bridlemile, Hayhurst, SWCC, etc. all received votes as better options than Gray.

- **Consider replacing MLC with Lincoln HS or Chapman ES (Title I).** Some community members have safety and parking concerns about MLC.

- **Add a few painless stops that are *directly* on existing routes to improve accessibility for ACCESS families.** e.g.: Beaumont MS, Rigler ES (Title I), or Scott ES (Title I); a stop on the south side of SE Powell in the 60s (for families who specifically requested not having to cross Powell to access this route); SE 52nd & Flavel for Woodstock families (if no move to Woodstock ES); Burlingame Fred Meyer; a NW stop. We understand that route times can't get much longer, but even one or two extra stops on some routes could make a big difference. Given a proposed reduction of over 100 stops, adding 5-10 total stops back is a reasonable request.



- **Allow connections to the existing PPS transportation system where possible.** Allow boarding at the originating elementary schools in the mornings; allow students to ride their neighborhood buses to elementary schools to catch ACCESS buses in the morning; allow ACCESS students to ride middle school buses from hubs in the afternoons; etc.

- **Check route times to ensure they're actually under 40 minutes at rush hour.** Several of our current routes consistently take 10-15 minutes longer than scheduled, meaning that students consistently arrive late to school. Consider moving ACCESS's start time 10-15 minutes later if needed based on the "real" route times.

- **Be aware that large, full buses may require significant behavior management.**

- **Clarify and standardize hub stop supervision protocol.**

- **Request that aftercare programs in neighborhood schools accept ACCESS students**

- **Expand high school TriMet pass program to ACCESS middle schoolers who apply.**

- **Review adopted system as needed and in one year in light of right-sizing.**

Next Steps

The transportation team will review the input and feedback and make adjustments to the HUB model if possible without incurring additional cost. The 1 million dollar savings is non-negotiable with this fragile budget.

Trade Offs

With the proposed HUB model we are expecting to yield $1,000,000 in savings for next year's budget. Which means we have a delta of $500,000 that we need to account for with trade offs. Our proposed tradeoffs are listed below:



Trade off proposal	Cost Savings	Impact	Mitigation
Reduce Contracted Student Behavior Support on buses	$150,000	Principals will not be able to request additional bus student behavior support for non-sped students.	Schools can determine appropriate school/bus discipline as noted in our Student Rights and Responsibilities Handbook.
Reduce Student Travel Equity Fund Allocation	$130,000	Based on recent expenditure data, the $130,000 savings is based upon the average unspent funds we have seen over the previous two years. Given schools have not been utilizing their entire allotment there would be little impact.	Schools will continue to receive an allocation based on the number of HU students that they serve.
Eliminate Centralized CSA	$160,000	Security has a central budget of $61,000 for schools which	School admin teams would need to plan accordingly and ensure that all



overtime for athletic events		we always over spend. High schools will be allocated a portion of this amount. If high schools would like additional coverage outside of their allocation they would need to pay out of their school budgets.	administrators are present when CSA coverage is reduced.
Total Cost Savings for 26-27	$440,000		